

Chapter 1. What You Are Working With

What You Are Working With

Section A of Paper 2 is worth **5 marks across 4 questions**, with a recommended time allocation of **10–15 minutes**. The section presents two thematically linked texts—Text 1 and Text 2—at least one of which includes visuals such as images, graphics, or icons. At least one question requires cross-text comparison.

This chapter covers two things you need to understand *before* you answer any question: the types of visual text that appear in the exam, and how to recognise the difference between formal and informal register across paired texts.

Section A — Visual Text Categories

Seven main categories of visual text may appear in the exam. The table below lists each category, common examples, and the features to look for when analysing them.

Visual Text Categories and Features		
Category	Examples	What to Look For
Advertisements	Product ads, service ads, PSAs	Persuasive language, call to action, slogans
Posters	Event posters, awareness campaigns	Bold headlines, images, dates/venues, logos
Social media posts	Instagram, Facebook, X (Twitter)	Hashtags, informal register, @mentions
Infographics	Data displays, statistical summaries	Charts, icons, statistics, colour coding
Web pages / Blogs	Website excerpts, blog entries	Hyperlinks, navigation, headings
Flyers / Brochures	Promotional leaflets	Layout sections, offers, fine print
Notices / Newsletters	School notices, community letters	Formal register, specific instructions

Typical Text Pairing

Expect one traditional visual text (e.g. advertisement, poster) paired with one digital short-form text (e.g. social media post). Video texts are excluded.

Section B — Recognising Register and Tone

When two texts are paired on the same theme, they often differ in register. Recognising these differences is essential for comparison questions (ACED step **E**). The table below provides a quick reference for distinguishing formal from informal register.

Register Comparison Chart

Feature	Formal Register	Informal Register
Vocabulary	Sophisticated, precise (“commence”, “participate”)	Everyday, casual (“start”, “join in”)
Pronouns	Third person or passive voice	“You”, “we”, direct address
Sentences	Complex, longer sentences	Short, punchy sentences; fragments
Punctuation	Minimal exclamation marks	Exclamation marks, ellipses, hashtags
Tone	Authoritative, measured, objective	Enthusiastic, personal, conversational
Typical text type	Official notices, reports, formal ads	Social media posts, casual blog entries

Chapter 2. The ACED Method

The ACED Method

ACED is a direct answering method for Section A. Each of the first three letters (A–C–E) maps to a specific question type and its sentence structure. The fourth letter (D) is a final mechanical check. This chapter is the core of the study guide: for every question type, you will find the method, the sentence template, a worked example, and the most common mistake to avoid.

Before You Answer

Read both texts fully—left to right, top to bottom—including ALL fine print, captions, logos, hashtags, and footnotes. Then use the ACED method below.

Section A — Overview and Quick Classification

The ACED Method

Step	What to Do
A Assess Each Option	MCQ/tick-box questions: eliminate wrong options against specific evidence, verify the best answer, count your ticks.
C Connotation, Not Definition	Language inference questions: explain the implied meaning (connotation), NOT the dictionary definition. Link to purpose.
E Evidence From Both Texts	Comparison and two-mark sub-part questions: reference BOTH texts by name. For 2-mark questions, give two distinct points.
D Double-Check	No questions skipped, no excess ticks, 2-mark questions have 2 points, comparison answers name both texts.

Quick Classification:

See “which of the following” or “tick”? → **A** — Assess Each Option.

See “what does the word/phrase suggest”? → **C** — Connotation, Not Definition.

See “which phrase echoes” or a tick-box grid comparing both texts? → **E** — Evidence From Both Texts.

Finished all questions? → **D** — Double-Check.

Section B — [A] Assess Each Option — MCQ / Tick-Box (1 mark)

For MCQ and tick-box questions, the sentence structure applies to your *mental reasoning process*—the internal check you perform before ticking a box.

Question Type 1: Select the best option

Technique: Eliminate wrong answers one by one against specific evidence, verify the best remaining option, then count your ticks to match the number required.

Step 1 (Eliminate): “Option [A/B/C] is incorrect because [specific reason it does not match the text].”

Step 2 (Verify): “Option [X] is the best answer because [specific evidence from the text] shows that [reason it fits].”

Step 3 (Count): “The question asks me to tick [N] box(es). I have ticked exactly [N]. This matches.”

Worked Example 1 — MCQ

Question: Which of the following would be the most effective title for Text 1?

(a) Save Our Planet (b) Earth Day Fun Run (c) How Pollution Affects Wildlife

Eliminate: (b) is incorrect because Text 1 is an awareness advertisement, not a fun run promotion. (c) is too narrow because Text 1 addresses environmental action broadly, not only pollution and wildlife.

Verify: (a) is the best answer because the image of hands passing a globe and the phrase “We still have a chance to make a big difference” both centre on the idea of saving the planet through collective action.

Count: The question asks me to tick 1 box. I have ticked exactly 1. **Answer:** (a).

Common Mistake: Ticking Excess Boxes

Ticking **more boxes than the question stipulates** results in **zero marks** for that question—even if all your correct answers are among those ticked. Always count carefully before committing.

Section C — [C] Connotation, Not Definition — Language Inference (1 mark)

For language inference questions, give the connotation or implication of the word or phrase—not the dictionary definition. Link the implied meaning to the text’s purpose.

Question Type 2: Explain what a word or phrase suggests

Technique: Identify the technical term for the language feature, quote the word or phrase exactly, then explain its implied meaning and link it to the text’s purpose.

Full structure: “The [technical term] ‘[exact word/phrase]’ suggests that [implied meaning], which [effect on the reader linked to purpose].”

Simplified: “The word ‘[word]’ suggests that [implied meaning], which conveys a sense of [connotation] that [links to purpose].”

Worked Example 2 — Language Inference

Question: What does the word ‘still’ in ‘We still have a chance to make a big difference’ suggest?

The word “still” suggests that the opportunity to protect the environment is narrowing and may not last much longer, which creates a sense of urgency to persuade readers to take immediate action before it is too late.

1 mark for identifying the connotation of urgency / diminishing opportunity.

Common Mistake: Defining Instead of Inferring

Students lose marks by giving the dictionary definition instead of the implied meaning in context. “Still” does not mean “motionless” here—it implies urgency and a closing window of opportunity. Always ask: what does this word *suggest*, not what does it *mean*?

Key Language Features — Technical Terms

Technical Term	Definition and Example
Imperative	A command that directs the reader (“Join us!”, “Act now!”, “Discover”)
Personal pronoun	“you” (direct address) and “we” (inclusive, builds community)
Rhetorical question	A question not expecting an answer, designed to provoke thought
Alliteration	Repetition of initial consonant sounds for emphasis or memorability
Emotive language	Words chosen to trigger an emotional response (“devastating”, “heartwarming”)
Hyperbole	Deliberate exaggeration for emphasis (“the best deal ever”)
Repetition	Repeating words or phrases to reinforce a message
Hashtags	Digital markers signalling community engagement and topic grouping

Section D — [E] Evidence From Both Texts — Comparison (1 mark)

Cross-text comparison questions require you to draw explicit connections between both texts. Analysing only one text forfeits marks entirely.

Question Type 3: Find a phrase that echoes an idea across texts

Technique: Locate a phrase in Text 2 that has synonymous meaning to a phrase in Text 1 (or vice versa). Match word form where possible (e.g. adjective + noun = adjective + noun).

Echo structure: “The phrase ‘[phrase from Text 2]’ in Text 2 echoes the idea of ‘[phrase from Text 1]’ in Text 1, as both convey the meaning of [shared idea in your own words].”

Contrast structure: “While Text 1 uses [feature] to create a [tone/effect], Text 2 employs [feature] to achieve a [tone/effect], suggesting that Text [1/2] adopts a more [formal/informal/urgent/personal] approach.”

Worked Example 3 — Cross-Text Comparison

Question: Which phrase in Text 2 echoes the idea of ‘a big difference’ in Text 1?

The phrase “a real impact” in Text 2 echoes the idea of “a big difference” in Text 1, as both convey the meaning that individual actions can produce significant positive change for the environment.
Match word form: adjective + noun = adjective + noun.

Common Mistake: Analysing Only One Text

Comparison questions require references to **both** texts. Answering about only one text forfeits marks entirely. Always name both Text 1 and Text 2 in your answer.

Section E — [E] Evidence From Both Texts — Two-Mark Sub-Part (2 marks)

Two-mark sub-part questions test comparative analysis across both texts. Each sub-part earns 1 mark independently. Always provide two distinct points.

Question Type 4: Compare both texts using a tick-box grid or written response

Technique: For tick-box grids, apply internal reasoning to each row independently. For written responses, structure two separate points—one about each text.

Tick-box grid: “Statement [X] applies to [Text 1 / Text 2 / Both / Neither] because [specific evidence from the relevant text(s)].”

Written: “Point 1: Text 1 uses [evidence] to [effect], which [link to purpose]. Point 2: In contrast, Text 2 uses [evidence] to [effect], which [link to purpose].”

Critical: Two marks = two distinct points. Each sub-part earns 1 mark independently.

Worked Example 4 — Two-Mark Sub-Part

Question: For each statement below, tick whether it applies to Text 1 only, Text 2 only, Both, or Neither.

(a) Uses a hashtag to build community engagement.

Text 1 (the advertisement) does not contain a hashtag. Text 2 (the social media post) uses #Earth-Day. **Answer: Text 2 only. [1 mark]**

(b) Uses an imperative to encourage the reader to take action.

Text 1 uses the imperative “Join us.” Text 2 uses the imperative “Share your story.” Both texts use imperatives. **Answer: Both. [1 mark]**

Common Mistake: Single Point for Two Marks

If the question is worth 2 marks, you must give **two distinct points**. Check the mark allocation before writing. One point earns a maximum of 1 mark.

Section F — Purpose, Audience, and Image Questions

Purpose, audience, and image questions do not map neatly to a single ACED letter but appear frequently in Section A. The techniques below apply regardless of which ACED step you are in.

Question Type 5: State the purpose or audience of a text

Technique: Identify the specific target audience, choose a strong action verb (persuade, educate, warn, encourage—not “tell” or “get”), and state the desired response.

Step 1: Identify the specific target audience (never “everyone” or “the general public”).

Step 2: Choose a strong action verb: persuade, educate, warn, encourage.

Step 3: State the desired response: what the audience should do or feel.

Purpose and Audience: Full-Mark vs Weak Answers

	Full-Mark Example	Weak Example
Purpose	To persuade young Singaporeans concerned about the environment to participate in the Earth Day clean-up event.	To tell people about Earth Day.
Audience	Environmentally conscious teenagers and young adults, as indicated by the informal register and use of hashtags.	Everyone.

Common Mistake: Vague Purpose Language

“To tell people about something” cannot earn full marks. Examiners require a **specific audience**, a **strong verb**, and a **desired response**. Also note: the purpose of the *text* is not the same as the purpose of the *event* it promotes.

Question Type 6: Explain how an image supports the text’s message

Technique: Describe the image precisely (what it shows), then link it to the text’s purpose in a second sentence. Each part earns 1 mark.

Step 1 (Describe): State precisely what the image shows. Be specific, not vague.

Step 2 (Link + Explain): Connect the image to the text’s message, explaining how it supports the purpose.

Worked Example 5 — Image Support

Question: How does the image support the message of the advertisement?

Describe: The image shows a pair of hands passing a globe to another pair of hands, suggesting an act of care and responsibility.

Link + Explain: This supports the advertisement’s message that environmental protection is a shared duty passed between generations, reinforcing the call to action for readers to participate in the Earth Day campaign.

Common Mistake: Description Without Link

Describing the image alone earns only 1 mark. The second mark requires linking the image to the text’s message. Always add a second sentence explaining *how* the image supports the purpose.

Chapter 3. Practice Questions

Practice Questions

The questions below are graded from straightforward to challenging. They cover every question type and ACED step from Chapter 2.

Section A — [A] Assess Each Option

Practice — MCQ and Tick-Box

1. A question asks “Which of the following would be the most effective title for Text 1?” Write out your three-step internal reasoning process using the Eliminate–Verify–Count structure.
2. A tick-box question asks you to tick two features that create a sense of urgency. You are confident about three options. Explain what you should do and why.
3. Text 1 is a poster for a school fundraiser. The options for the best title are: (a) “Give Generously” (b) “School Fundraiser 2025” (c) “How Charities Operate.” Eliminate the weakest option and verify the best, with reasoning.

Section B — [C] Connotation, Not Definition

Practice — Language Inference

4. What does the word “discover” in “Discover a world of possibilities” suggest? Answer using the full sentence structure from Chapter 2.
5. A text reads “Our planet is crying out for help.” Identify the language feature used and explain its effect on the reader, linking it to the text’s purpose.
6. Explain the difference between giving the *definition* and the *connotation* of a word in an inference question. Use an example.

Section C — [E] Evidence From Both Texts

Practice — Comparison and Two-Mark Sub-Part

7. Text 1 uses the phrase “lasting change.” Text 2 uses the phrase “permanent transformation.” Write a sentence explaining how Text 2 echoes Text 1, using the echo structure from Chapter 2.
8. A tick-box grid asks whether the statement “Uses emotive language to persuade the reader” applies to Text 1, Text 2, Both, or Neither. Text 1 uses the word “devastating” and Text 2 uses “heartbreaking.” State your answer with reasoning.
9. A 2-mark question asks you to compare how Text 1 and Text 2 encourage the reader to take action. Write two distinct points, one about each text.

Section D — Purpose, Audience, and Images

Practice — Purpose, Audience, and Image Questions

10. A poster advertises a blood donation drive at a community centre. State the purpose using the three-component formula.
11. An Instagram post about a school charity run uses the hashtag #RunForACause and the phrase “Sign up today!” Identify the target audience and explain your reasoning.
12. An advertisement shows a family smiling around a dinner table with the headline “Nothing brings us together like a home-cooked meal.” Describe the image and explain how it supports the message.
13. A text uses the verb “get” in “Get involved today!” Suggest a stronger verb and explain why it is more effective.
14. Why is “the audience is everyone” considered a weak answer? Explain with reference to the three-component formula.

Section E — Mixed — Exam-Style Questions

Practice — Mixed Exam-Style

15. Classify each of the following questions by ACED step (A, C, or E):
 - (a) “What does the phrase ‘time is running out’ suggest?”
 - (b) “Which phrase in Text 2 echoes the idea of ‘a better future’ in Text 1?”
 - (c) “Tick the most effective title for Text 1.”
16. A student answers an inference question by writing: “The word ‘still’ means something that is not moving.” Explain what is wrong with this answer and write a corrected version.
17. After completing all four questions in Section A, list four things you should verify during the ACED Double-Check (D) step.
18. A student ticks three boxes when the question asks for two. The student’s three selections include both correct answers. How many marks does the student receive? Explain.

Chapter 4. Quick Reference

Quick Reference

This chapter is designed to be photocopied or torn out as a one-page revision card.

Section A — The ACED Method — Complete Summary

Before answering: Read both texts fully, including all fine print, captions, logos, hashtags, and footnotes.

A — Assess Each Option: MCQ/tick-box? Eliminate wrong options, verify the best answer, count your ticks.

C — Connotation, Not Definition: Inference? Give the implied meaning, not the dictionary meaning. Link to purpose.

E — Evidence From Both Texts: Comparison or sub-part? Name both texts. Two marks = two distinct points.

D — Double-Check: No questions skipped, no excess ticks, 2-mark questions have 2 points, both texts named.

Section B — Sentence Structure Templates

[A] MCQ reasoning:

“Option [X] is incorrect because [reason]. Option [Y] is correct because [evidence]. I have ticked [N] boxes.”

[C] Inference:

“The [technical term] ‘[word/phrase]’ suggests that [implied meaning], which [effect linked to purpose].”

[E] Echo comparison:

“The phrase ‘[Text 2 phrase]’ in Text 2 echoes ‘[Text 1 phrase]’ in Text 1, as both convey [shared meaning].”

[E] Two-mark:

“Point 1: Text 1 uses [evidence] to [effect]. Point 2: Text 2 uses [evidence] to [effect].”

Purpose/Audience:

“The purpose is to [strong verb] [specific audience] to [desired response].”

Image support:

“The image shows [description], which supports the message that [link to purpose].”

Section C — Technical Terms to Memorise

Term	What It Means
Imperative	Command directing the reader (“Join us!”)
Personal pronoun	“you” (direct address), “we” (inclusive)
Rhetorical question	Question not expecting an answer
Alliteration	Repetition of initial consonant sounds
Emotive language	Words triggering emotional response
Hyperbole	Deliberate exaggeration
Repetition	Repeating words/phrases for reinforcement
Hashtags	Digital community markers